



Interviewer Covenant

The Promise Made · The Promise Kept

*The interviewer's responsibility is not to validate LifeBook.
It is to understand people truthfully.*

This document establishes how a LifeBook interviewer thinks before it teaches what a LifeBook interviewer does. It does not describe procedures. Those belong in the Customer Discovery Operations Manual. What this Covenant describes is the philosophy — and the commitment — that makes trustworthy evidence possible.

A LifeBook interviewer's responsibility is not to validate LifeBook. It is to understand people truthfully. These are not the same task, and conflating them is the most consequential failure in customer discovery. The evidence we collect will form part of the foundation on which LifeBook is built. That evidence must be clean.

This Covenant is signed before the first calibration interview. It is not a legal document. It is a moral and professional commitment — to the participants who entrust us with their stories, and to the integrity of the evidence on which LifeBook will be built.

PRINCIPLE I • CURIOSITY BEFORE CERTAINTY

Every interview begins with the assumption that we have something to learn.

The purpose of customer discovery is not to confirm what LifeBook believes. It is to discover whether reality agrees. A LifeBook interviewer approaches every conversation as a student — curious, patient, and genuinely willing to be wrong. If we already know what we will find, we are not conducting research. We are staging it.

PRINCIPLE II • NEVER PERSUADE

If a participant misunderstands LifeBook, that misunderstanding is evidence — not a problem to solve.

The instinct to correct a participant is almost always the instinct to protect an assumption. A participant who misunderstands the purpose of LifeBook is telling us something important about how the concept communicates. A participant who understands it but disagrees is telling us something more valuable still. Neither deserves a correction. Both deserve deeper questions.

PRINCIPLE III • NEVER DEFEND

Criticism is information. It is never an invitation to explain.

When a participant criticizes LifeBook — its concept, its value, its timing, its relevance — the correct response is curiosity. "Tell me more about that" is almost always the right answer. Defending LifeBook during an interview contaminates the evidence. It teaches the participant what answer we are hoping for, and it transforms an honest conversation into a performance.

PRINCIPLE IV • SILENCE HAS VALUE

When silence follows a question, allow it. Thinking happens in silence.

Do not rephrase a question because a participant hesitates. Rephrasing is often the most subtle way an interviewer steers a participant toward an expected answer. Ask the question once. Then wait. The pause between a question and an honest answer is not a failure — it is the interval in which genuine reflection occurs. An interviewer who fills silence with clarification is an interviewer who has stopped listening.

PRINCIPLE V • THE INSTRUMENT IS INVISIBLE

The best interview feels like a conversation. If a participant notices they are being studied, something has broken down.

The questions in the Interview Guide exist to create structured space for honest reflection — not to signal rigor or demonstrate preparation. Participants who feel observed become performers. A LifeBook interview should feel like a thoughtful conversation between two people who are genuinely curious about the same things. When the instrument is invisible, the participant is free to tell the truth.

PRINCIPLE VI • OBSERVE FIRST. INTERPRET LATER.

What a participant says is an observation. What it means is an interpretation. These must never be treated as the same thing.

During the interview, capture what participants say. After the interview — in the debrief and synthesis — consider what those statements might mean. Collapsing these two acts in the moment is the most common way evidence becomes confirmation. A participant who says "I've never thought about preserving my memories that way" has stated a fact. What that fact means for LifeBook is a separate, subsequent question — one that belongs in the debrief, not the interview room.

PRINCIPLE VII • CONTRADICTION HAS EQUAL VALUE

Evidence that challenges a LifeBook hypothesis is as valuable as evidence that confirms one.

An interviewer who feels relief when participants validate LifeBook has already compromised the research. An interviewer who feels disappointment when participants

resist it has done the same. The interviewer's responsibility is to welcome both with equal curiosity. Confirmation tells us what is working. Contradiction tells us what is at risk of being wrong. Both are essential. A discovery process that produces only confirmation has not been rigorous — it has been lucky.

STEWARDSHIP

Every participant has entrusted us with part of their story. That trust belongs to them.

A LifeBook interview invites people to reflect on how they preserve their lives, their memories, and the relationships that matter most to them. These are not neutral topics. Participants may share things they have never articulated before. They may find the conversation unexpectedly personal. A LifeBook interviewer receives these moments with patience, respect, humility, confidentiality, and gratitude — and never uses them to advance an argument.

The participant's willingness to be present, honest, and open is a gift. The interviewer's responsibility is to be worthy of it.

CALIBRATION BEFORE CERTIFICATION

No interviewer conducts evidence-generating interviews before calibration is complete.

The first interviews are not customer research. They are interviewer development. Like a scientist who calibrates their instruments before collecting data, LifeBook calibrates its interviewers before trusting their evidence. The quality of the evidence we collect is only as good as the quality of the instrument that collects it.

Calibration is complete — and certification may proceed — when all four of the following criteria have been met:

1. Recorded calibration interviews demonstrate no systematic pattern of leading questions, verified through recording review with the Certification Authority.
2. Conversations in calibration recordings demonstrate that the participant, not the interviewer, determines the direction of the conversation.
3. At least one calibration interview has been conducted with a participant who has no prior knowledge of LifeBook.
4. In a formal debrief with the Certification Authority, the interviewer demonstrates the ability to articulate what was observed separately from what was interpreted in at least one calibration interview — without conflating the two. This criterion tests whether the principles of this Covenant have been internalized, not merely performed.

Certification is not a milestone to be celebrated. It is a threshold to be crossed honestly.

THE COMMITMENT

I have read and understood the principles of this Covenant. I commit to the following — not as a formal obligation, but as a professional and moral one.

I will enter every interview as a student — curious, patient, and willing to be wrong.

I will listen to understand, not to confirm.

I will receive criticism as information and silence as thought.

I will not defend LifeBook in an interview. I will not persuade participants toward any conclusion. I will not rescue an idea that is failing.

I will separate what I observe from what I believe it means, and I will not collapse that distinction under the pressure of optimism.

I will treat every participant's story with the same care I would want my own to receive.

I will not conduct evidence-generating interviews until I have demonstrated readiness — and I will hold myself to that standard honestly, not optimistically.

Interviewer Signature

Print Name

Date



